(U) Situation in Fallujah, 29 April 2004

(U) Coalition close air support (CAS) was provided by Marine rotary-wing aircraft (AH-1W Cobra and UH-1N Huey gunships) firing Hellfire and TOW missiles, 2.75 high-explosive (HE) and flechette rockets, and 20-mm, .50-cal and 7.62-mm rounds. Fixed-wing CAS was provided by F-15E, F-16CG, F-16C+, AC-130U, F-18C, and F-14B aircraft that flew over 1000 CAS sorties, dropping 70 GBU-12's, 2 GBU-31's, 1 AGM-65H, 1 Hellfire missile, and numerous 20-mm, 105-mm, 40-mm, and 25-mm rounds. Insurgents feared the AC-130 the most; its firepower, combined with real-time surveillance provided by loitering unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), quickly discouraged most insurgent maneuver at night.

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) Multiple reporting indicates insurgent strength numbered between 500 and 1000 fighters. They fought with primarily small arms, rocket-propelled grenades (RPGs), machineguns (MGs), improvised explosive devices (IEDs), and mortars. The enemy operated in small fire-team-size elements that conducted hit-and-run attacks, moving building to building to remain elusive and falling back on pre-positioned weapon and supply caches.

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) After two days of fighting, 2/1 had penetrated into the northeast Jolan area, while 1/5 seized a huge foothold in the southeast industrial sector to use as a staging ground for subsequent Marine patrols deeper into Fallujah. Marine patrols began to push up against the south side of Highway 10 (a major road that bisects the city east to west) almost immediately.

(U) Throughout the fight Coalition forces allowed nonmilitary-age men, women, and children to exit through the cordon (at least 60,000) and humanitarian supplies to enter. On 9 April 2004, Marines handed out MREs and water to a caravan of vehicles that stretched over 1.5 miles.

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) Roughly 2000 Iraqi soldiers and policemen also deployed in support. Most of the Iraqi forces deserted soon after fighting began, forcing some Marine units to reposition to fill their intended spots in the cordon around the city. For example, of the 700 Iraqi soldiers of the 2d New Iraqi Army Bn, 38% evaporated from their posts after taking some fire in a convoy on their way to Fallujah on 5 April. An exception was the 36th Iraqi National Guard Battalion (400 Iraqis, 17 SF advisors), which fought well alongside 2/1 in the Jolan neighborhood.